Six Sigma

Used in organizations to strive for near-perfect products and services, Six Sigma is a disciplined, data-driven approach for eliminating defects in any process.

How it works

The idea is that measuring the number of defects in any process makes it possible to systematically work out how to eliminate them and get as close to zero defects as possible. Individuals are trained to become experts in the different methods, creating a cadre of black belts, green belts, and champions.

Every Six Sigma project is carefully documented, follows a defined sequence of steps, and has quantified value targets, such as increasing customer satisfaction or reducing costs. To achieve Six Sigma quality, a manufacturing process must have 99.99966 percent of output free of defects (3.4 defective parts per million).

SIX SIGMA ROLES

Six Sigma professionals are experts at improving processes. They drive the implementation of change.

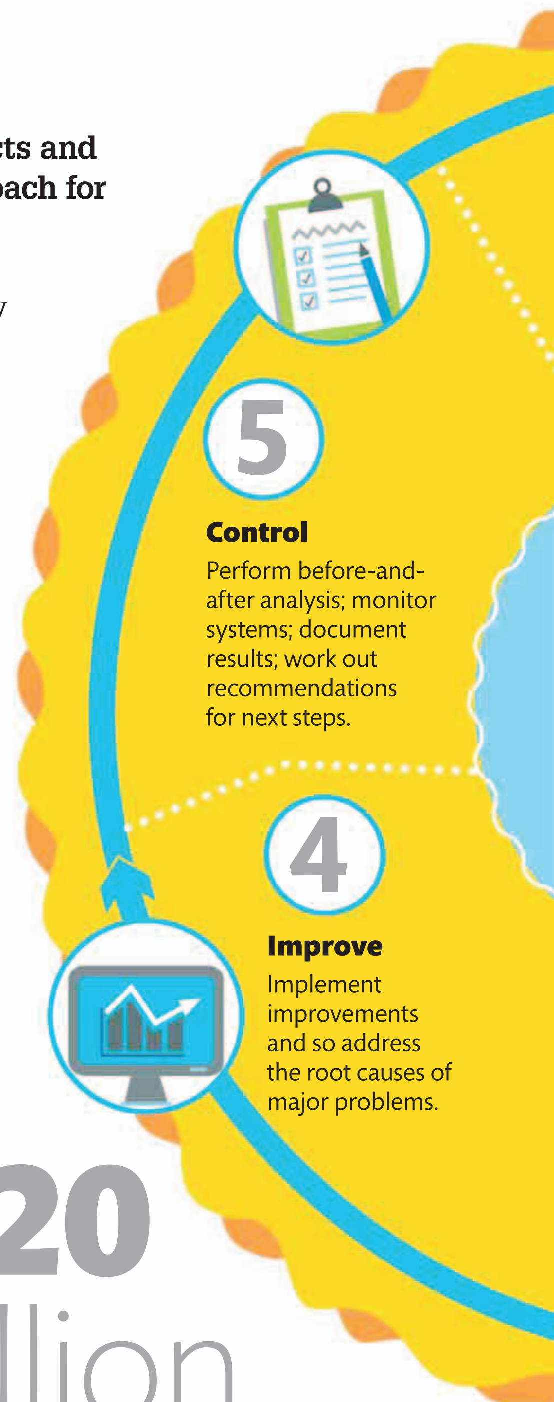
Master black belt Trains and coaches black belts and green belts; works at highest level, developing key measures and the strategic direction

Black belt Leads problem-solving projects; coaches project teams, assigning roles and responsibilities; trains green belts

Green belt Leads green-belt projects; helps with data collection and analysis for black-belt projects

Champions Translate the company's vision, mission, and goals to create an organizational deployment (OD) plan and identify individual projects

Executives Provide overall alignment by establishing strategic focus of the Six Sigma program within the context of the organization's culture and its vision of what the customer sees and feels



$320 million

the sum saved by General Electric with Six Sigma in 1997